Capstone - Voraa

GenTag-Enhanced Personalization & Smart Categorization for Underutilized Venues

Executive Summary

This report analyzes user behavior, product experience, and decision-making processes related to **Voraa**, a two-sided local commerce platform designed to help users discover nearby restaurants and redeem coupons through a streamlined discovery-to-conversion journey. The study focuses on identifying the key barriers to user acquisition and retention while evaluating the effectiveness of **GenTags**, Voraa's internal tagging system used to describe venues and personalize recommendations.

Voraa aims to grow its user base and reach a near-term target of **$20K in monthly recurring revenue**, which requires approximately **2,000 paying users**. However, current analytics suggest that while the platform has some user engagement, monetization and retention remain below target levels. Retention drops sharply after the first day of use, indicating that many users do not experience a clear "value moment" during their initial interaction with the app. In addition, the current user base is geographically misaligned with Voraa's near-term focus on the Seattle market, highlighting the need to strengthen local relevance and product clarity.

To investigate these issues, the research team conducted **12 structured interviews with Seattle-based participants** aged 20–30. Participants explored the Voraa app and discussed their restaurant discovery behaviors, expectations, and pain points. Interview data were analyzed using thematic coding to identify recurring behavioral patterns and product usability issues.

The findings reveal several key insights. First, **unclear product positioning** prevents users from quickly understanding how Voraa differs from existing tools such as Google Maps or Yelp, reducing new-user conversion. Second, **local restaurant inventory density** is critical for retention; users abandon the app quickly when they cannot find nearby venues that match their everyday dining habits. Third, **early onboarding friction**, including complex registration flows and interface issues, prevents users from experiencing value quickly. Fourth, **trust and credibility signals** strongly influence user decisions. Users are hesitant to redeem coupons when deal terms are unclear or when venue information lacks reviews and reliable proof signals.

The study also finds that **GenTags function most effectively as decision-support tools rather than persuasive recommendations**. Tags help users filter options and confirm choices more quickly when they are concrete, practical, and aligned with user intent, but they lose credibility when they appear promotional or excessive.

Based on these insights, the report recommends clarifying Voraa's **"deal-first" positioning**, prioritizing **merchant onboarding to increase Seattle venue density**, simplifying the **onboarding experience**, strengthening **credibility signals for deals and venues**, and redesigning **GenTags as a curated decision toolkit** that helps users narrow options quickly. By focusing on decision efficiency and trustworthy deal discovery, Voraa can reduce user friction and better position itself within the fragmented restaurant discovery ecosystem.

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1. Background

1.1 Product overview

Voraa is a two-sided local commerce platform. On the supply side, merchants join Voraa to publish coupons and offers. On the demand side, users discover nearby places, evaluate options, claim coupons, and redeem them in-store, forming a closed loop from discovery to conversion. To improve recommendation relevance and reduce decision friction, Voraa uses GenTag, an internal tag system that describes venues and user preferences and supports both recommendation ranking and recommendation explanations.

1.2 Why now

Voraa's near-term growth requires addressing two user-side constraints at the same time: **new user acquisition is not scaling in the intended market**, and **retention drops sharply after initial use**. The company's stated objective is $20k MRR, which implies approximately 2,000 paying users and a pace of about 500 new paying users per month. Current product analytics indicate a meaningful usage base overall, but monetization and market alignment suggest a sizable gap relative to that target.

Over a recent reporting window (Jan 12 – Feb 8, 2026), Voraa shows approximately 1.8K active users (30D), 733 active users (7D), and 147 active users (1D), with an average engagement time per active user of 9m 32s and 3.8 engaged sessions per user. At the same time, purchase revenue is approximately $4.7K in the same window, with average purchase revenue per active user around $2.94, which indicates that current revenue generation remains materially below a $20k monthly run-rate, even accounting for differences between revenue reporting and true recurring MRR.

Retention data further reinforces urgency. The retention curve shows a steep drop after Day 0, suggesting that while some users explore the product meaningfully during initial sessions, many do not return or do not reach a repeatable "value moment" that sustains habitual use. This makes improving the discovery-to-claim-to-redeem experience and clarifying the value of recommendations critical, because better first-session outcomes are a prerequisite for durable retention.

In addition, acquisition appears misaligned with the near-term Seattle growth focus. Recent active users are heavily concentrated outside the United States, with Mexico representing the largest share of active users (about 1.7K) while the United States accounts for a comparatively small number (about 60). For a local, two-sided marketplace, geographic density is a foundational requirement: users must see relevant nearby offers, and merchants must see credible local demand. This gap between current user geography and the intended Seattle market increases the importance of improving product clarity, trust, and conversion, so that Seattle-targeted acquisition efforts can translate into sustained usage and paying behavior.

Seattle is a practical focus market because it combines a dense local commerce environment with a large addressable population that can support a geographically concentrated rollout. The City of Seattle is estimated at 780,995 residents (July 1, 2024) (U.S. Census Bureau, 2024), and the Seattle–Tacoma–Bellevue MSA is approximately 4.15 million residents (2024) (Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, 2025). In addition, Seattle and King County attract substantial visitor traffic, with about 40 million visitors in 2024 and $8.8B in visitor spending, which strengthens the opportunity for discovery and deal-seeking behaviors that can translate into coupon claim and redeem activity (Visit Seattle, 2025).

1.3 Research scope

This report focuses on the interview transcripts and translates qualitative feedback into product and GenTag recommendations that directly support Voraa's user growth priorities. Specifically, the scope covers three areas:

- **Usage context and discovery behaviors:** characterizing the recurring situations in which users make restaurant decisions, how they enter and navigate discovery apps (search-first, browse-first, map-first), what motivates adoption, and what triggers early drop-off. We also situate Voraa within the broader multi-platform discovery ecosystem and the Seattle market context to clarify where Voraa can win in users' existing workflows.
- **End-to-end product experience:** identifying where users experience friction, confusion, or drop-off across the core Voraa journey, and summarizing the product capabilities users expect to complete discovery and redeem-related tasks confidently and independently.
- **GenTag experience and impact:** evaluating whether GenTags align with users' natural language and decision-making logic, and whether they meaningfully influence behaviors such as decision speed, confidence, exploration of unfamiliar venues, and perceived risk, including when tags become overwhelming or reduce trust.

2. Research Objectives and Questions

2.1 Objectives

O1. Understand usage context and discovery behaviors.
Characterize the recurring situations in which users make restaurant decisions, how they enter and navigate discovery apps (search-first, browse-first, map-first), what motivates adoption, and what triggers early drop-off.

O2. Diagnose friction and drop-off across the core Voraa flow.
Identify the highest-impact usability blockers and moments of uncertainty that prevent users from efficiently discovering venues, evaluating options, claiming coupons, and completing the redeem journey independently.

O3. Validate GenTag comprehension and the user mental model.
Understand how users interpret GenTags, how GenTags map to their natural decision language (food type vs vibe vs parking), and where terminology or presentation creates confusion or overload.

O4. Quantify GenTag's decision and trust impact directionally.
Evaluate whether and how GenTags influence decision speed, option elimination, willingness to explore unfamiliar venues, and perceived risk, including conditions under which tags feel persuasive or ad-like and therefore undermine trust.

2.2 Research questions

Usage context and behavior

- In what situations do users turn to restaurant discovery tools, and what signals do they need to decide quickly in each situation?
- How do users typically enter the experience (search-first, browse-first, map-first), and what navigation structure and filtering do they expect?
- What drives adoption or return, and what are the most common early drop-off triggers?

Flow pain points (Voraa experience)

- Where do users feel stuck, confused, or most likely to abandon the flow, and why?
- What missing or unclear product capabilities (search, filters, favorites, map, "why recommended") most limit task completion and confidence?

GenTag understanding (language and mental model)

- What do users believe GenTags represent, and how well do GenTags match the way users naturally describe places?
- When do tags feel helpful versus overwhelming or unclear?

Behavioral impact (decision-making and trust)

- Do GenTags meaningfully reduce decision effort (speed, confidence, ability to rule out options) or mainly provide extra context?
- Which tag types or display patterns increase trust and exploration, and which make the experience feel promotional or less credible?

3. Methodology

3.1 Participants

A total of **12 participants** were interviewed. Participants were recruited using **convenience sampling**, which was appropriate given the Capstone's compressed timeline and the need to quickly surface and prioritize potential user-facing business problems to inform subsequent front-end and back-end work. This approach enabled rapid access to participants who could provide early directional insights on core product flows and GenTag comprehension.

All participants were **Seattle-area residents**, ensuring geographic relevance to Voraa's near-term market focus. Recruitment also naturally resulted in **an age concentration in the 20–30 range**, which is a strategically relevant segment for Voraa's user growth: users in this cohort are typically more open to trying new digital products and, as students or early-career professionals, may be relatively more price-sensitive, making coupon discovery and redemption value propositions particularly salient. While participants shared some baseline similarities in location and general demographic profile, they exhibited meaningful variation in daily routines, dining and café-going behaviors, deal-seeking intensity, and use of discovery platforms, which supported comparison across different usage patterns.

Participant breakdown (n = 12)

- Gender: Female _6_, Male _6_
- Age: 20–24 _6_, 25–30 _6_
- Occupation: Students _9_, Early-career professionals _3_
- Seattle residency: Seattle-area residents _12_

3.2 Study design

Interviews were **structured**, following a standardized guide of 20 questions with predefined follow-up prompts where applicable. At the start of each session, participants were asked to explore the Voraa app independently for approximately 10 minutes. During this exploration period, the research team intentionally provided minimal guidance to observe natural user behaviors and points of confusion. Support was offered only if a participant explicitly asked for clarification or became unable to proceed.

The interview then proceeded through the question guide and concluded with an open-ended wrap-up, inviting participants to share any additional feedback or ideas not covered in the scripted questions. Each session lasted approximately **30–60 minutes**, and about 40% of interviews were conducted remotely.

3.3 Analysis approach and data handling

Coding Strategy

Analysis primarily used a **deductive coding** approach, supported by **inductive coding**. This project was designed around explicit business goals, and the interview guide was constructed accordingly. A deductive-first strategy helped keep analysis tightly aligned with the research objectives and reduced the risk of over-indexing on tangential details.

At the same time, individual experiences with Voraa varied meaningfully, and participants surfaced issues and opportunities that were not fully captured by the initial question set. To avoid limiting insights to the team's prior assumptions, the team incorporated **inductive coding after an initial deductive pass** to identify additional patterns that were both emergent in the data and relevant to the business goals. When repeated or high-impact new ideas appeared, new codes were added and applied consistently across transcripts.

Thematic Analysis

Following coding, the team synthesized codes into higher-level **themes** using a manual thematic analysis process. Codes were reviewed for overlap and consolidated where they represented the same underlying concept, then grouped into themes based on (1) conceptual similarity, (2) where they occurred in the user journey, and (3) their relevance to decision-making and trust. Themes were finalized when they were sufficiently distinct, supported by multiple participants or strong evidence, and could be translated into actionable product implications.

Reliability and quality checks

To improve coding reliability, the team used a **two-coder workflow** with cross-checking. Two team members independently coded a subset of transcripts, compared interpretations, and aligned on code definitions and inclusion criteria. Discrepancies were resolved through discussion and codebook refinement, which helped reduce individual bias and strengthen confidence that findings reflect patterns in the data rather than a single analyst's interpretation.

Additional analytical lenses

In addition to thematic analysis, the report applies the following lenses to strengthen interpretation and prioritization:

- **Frequency analysis:** summarizes how often key themes or codes were mentioned across participants. This helps differentiate widely shared issues from isolated comments and provides directional support for prioritization.
- **Negative case analysis:** intentionally reviews instances that contradict dominant patterns (for example, participants who did not experience a common pain point or interpreted GenTags differently). This improves analytical rigor by clarifying boundary conditions and identifying when a recommendation may not generalize across user types.
- **Data partitioning (for example, by gender and occupation) analysis:** compares themes across simple participant subgroups to explore whether needs or interpretations differ systematically. This helps avoid one-size-fits-all conclusions and informs whether certain design or messaging choices should be tailored by user segment.

3.4 Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings.

First, the use of convenience sampling means the participant pool is not fully representative of the broader Seattle population. For example, the sample skews toward graduate students and individuals in the 20–30 age range. As a result, findings may over-reflect the preferences and behaviors of these groups and should be generalized to the wider Seattle market with caution.

Second, the research primarily reflects concept-level validation rather than observed real-world outcomes. In practice, this means participants reacted to the product experience and the GenTag concept in an interview setting, often based on short-term exploration and self-reported intentions. The study therefore cannot fully determine how GenTags and flow changes would impact actual behavior over time.

Third, while the team used a structured coding process and cross-checking to improve consistency, coder interpretation bias may still exist. Researchers may unintentionally emphasize feedback that aligns with prior expectations, interpret ambiguous statements differently, or underweight less common perspectives. These risks were mitigated through a shared codebook and cross-review, but they cannot be eliminated entirely.

4. Usage Context and Discovery Behaviors

4.1 Usage situations

Across the 12 interviews, restaurant discovery behavior clusters into **four recurring usage situations** defined by social context and urgency:

1) **last-minute, low-effort decisions** after class or work, where users want the quickest path to "something close and open now" (e.g., P11, P12, P9)
2) **social/group decisions** when hanging out with friends and no one has a fixed plan, where users scan options, compare categories, and try to reach consensus (e.g., P4, P7, P8, P10, P12, P9)
3) **purpose-driven café scenarios** (often last-minute) such as finding a study spot, where constraints like walkability, Wi-Fi, chargers, seating, and noise level matter more than cuisine (e.g., P10, P7, P11, P12, P1)
4) **travel/new neighborhood exploration**, where users rely on discovery tools because they lack local "go-to" places and need trust/coverage signals quickly (e.g., P5, P7, P9, P11, P12, P6).

Importantly, many users do not "discover from scratch" inside a single app; instead, they combine channels—seeing a place on social media first, then using an app to validate details (menu, reviews, distance, and deals) (e.g., P1, P5, P9).

4.2 Adoption motivators

Motivations to adopt or return are consistently **value- and efficiency-driven**. Users are willing to try a new app when it **saves time**, **reduces decision fatigue**, and offers **clear, straightforward discounts** without hidden conditions (e.g., P2, P11, P12). Several participants framed the app's value as especially relevant for **everyday meals** and price-sensitive decisions, rather than fine dining (P2, P3, P10). Others emphasized **personal relevance** as the trigger: the app must quickly surface options that match their intent (cuisine, purpose, proximity), otherwise it fails the "10-minute test" and gets abandoned (P4, P1).

4.3 Drop-off triggers

Drop-off is driven by **early friction and perceived mismatch with reality**. The most common abandonment triggers are:

1) **limited local coverage** ("not enough places near me / not the places I'd actually go"), which makes browsing feel pointless (P1, P2, P3, P4)
2) **ad-heavy or disruptive experiences** such as pop-ups or overly promotional screens (P1, P2, P10)
3) **deal credibility issues** such as "bait-and-switch" discounts, fake coupons, or complex redemption constraints (P2, P7)

4) **membership/subscription gating** before users experience value (P9, P10).
5) A distinct but recurring scenario-specific drop-off trigger is **map/location failure**: many users open map first to assess walkability and distance—especially students without cars—so "empty map" or missing in-app location context directly breaks the primary job-to-be-done (P10, P9, P6, P7).

Overall, users tolerate a simple UI if it is fast and honest, but they quickly churn when the product feels inefficient, confusing, or untrustworthy in the first few minutes (P2, P11, P12).

4.4 App entry modes and navigation expectations

When users open a restaurant discovery app, their first actions typically follow **three entry modes**: **Search-first**, **Browse-first**, and **Map-first**, and the mode is strongly shaped by whether they already have a target in mind.

In **search-first** behavior, users go directly to the search bar because they already know the place or a specific craving, and the app is primarily used to retrieve details or confirm a decision (e.g., "I go straight to the search bar… I'm not really browsing," P1; P8; P12).

In **browse-first** behavior, users scan the home feed to see what is available and decide from the set of options—this is especially common when inventory is small, when users want "what's new," or when the decision is social and exploratory (P2, P3, P4, P7, P9, P10).

A third pattern, **map-first**, appears when users prioritize proximity and walkability; they want to answer "what's nearby and open now," and this becomes more pronounced among students without cars (P10, P12).

Across modes, users carry clear expectations for navigation structure: they want to **narrow quickly** via categories/filters (cuisine, purpose, practical constraints), then validate with high-signal details. Many users explicitly described opening the homepage and tapping **categories first** (P4, P10), or browsing then switching to search once they have a candidate (P5). Another repeated expectation is that the product should help them **reduce decision space early**—either through filters, a clean hierarchy, or a short set of relevant tags—because cluttered or poorly classified information makes it hard to know where to start (P6, P7). Users also rely on **ratings/reviews as an entry heuristic**, such as immediately scanning for "highest-rated around me" (P9) or treating overly sponsored placements as ads and ignoring them (P1, P7, P9, P11, P12). This explains why "Recommended for you" modules often receive low engagement unless they align tightly with user intent; several participants click recommendations only when they match their category or recent behavior, otherwise they ignore them as irrelevant or promotional (P1, P2, P4, P11, P12). In short, entry behavior is goal-directed: users either arrive with a candidate and want fast confirmation, or arrive with an intent and want rapid narrowing plus trustworthy validation signals.

4.5 Seattle market readiness

Seattle presents a favorable environment for restaurant discovery platforms due to a combination of strong technology adoption, a dense urban food scene, and a large population of young professionals and students. The city's economy continues to be driven by technology and innovation sectors, creating a highly educated population with strong digital tool adoption behaviors (Accio, 2026). Over 28% of residents hold a bachelor's degree and a significant portion work in technology or knowledge-based industries, which correlates with higher usage of mobile services and recommendation platforms.

Seattle also maintains a dynamic and continuously evolving restaurant ecosystem. Restaurant listings have continued to grow modestly between 2023 and 2025 as the dining industry gradually recovered from pandemic disruption (OysterLink, 2025). At the same time, consumer demand has shifted toward personalized and experience-driven dining, with strong interest in niche cuisines, specialty coffee shops, and unique dining concepts (Accio, 2026). These trends create a favorable landscape for discovery tools that can help users navigate a large and constantly changing set of venues.

However, rising dining costs also shape consumer decision behavior. In the Seattle region, prices for food away from home increased by approximately 7.6% year-over-year in 2025, significantly faster than general inflation (Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025). This cost pressure increases the importance of value signals such as discounts, deals, and price transparency in restaurant discovery tools.

Additionally, broader dining behavior trends reinforce the importance of speed and convenience. National restaurant industry data indicate that younger consumers increasingly prioritize quick decision-making and value-oriented dining experiences, with takeout and fast decision pathways becoming dominant consumption patterns. This aligns closely with patterns observed in the interviews, where participants frequently opened restaurant apps in last-minute decision scenarios.

Taken together, these signals suggest that **Seattle is a high-readiness market for restaurant discovery platforms**: users are digitally fluent, the restaurant landscape is dense and dynamic, and economic conditions increase demand for efficient and value-oriented dining decisions.

4.6 Discovery ecosystem

Restaurant discovery in Seattle operates within a multi-platform ecosystem rather than a single dominant application. Interviews indicate that users rely on a combination of search engines, review platforms, and social media channels when deciding where to eat. Instead of performing all decision steps in one application, users typically move across several platforms, each serving a different function within the discovery process.

Discovery Platform Roles

Across interviews, four primary tools consistently appeared in users' restaurant discovery workflows: Google Maps, Yelp, social media platforms (Instagram/Xiaohongshu), and reservation platforms like OpenTable. These tools collectively form the core infrastructure of restaurant discovery behavior.

Google Maps functions as the **primary location discovery layer**. Participants frequently described opening Google Maps when they want to quickly understand what is nearby, what is open, and how to navigate to a location (P7, P9, P12). Its integration with navigation, operating hours, and map-based search makes it the default entry point for proximity-driven decisions.

Yelp serves a complementary role as a **review validation platform**. Users typically turn to Yelp when they want to assess reputation through ratings, reviews, and user photos before committing to a restaurant (P11, P12). Yelp continues to be one of the most influential review platforms globally, hosting over 244 million cumulative reviews as of 2024 (Yelp Inc., 2024).

Social media platforms such as Instagram and Xiaohongshu increasingly function as **inspiration channels**. Several interview participants reported discovering restaurants first through social media posts or recommendations before turning to other tools to verify details such as location, menu, and pricing (P1, P5, P9). This reflects a broader trend in which younger consumers rely on visual content and social recommendations as the starting point for restaurant discovery.

Reservation platforms such as OpenTable appear later in the process when booking becomes necessary. These tools typically facilitate the **transaction stage** of the decision journey rather than the discovery stage.

Taken together, these platforms form a layered discovery ecosystem in which different tools support different steps of the dining decision process: social media provides inspiration, search and maps identify nearby options, review platforms validate choices, and reservation platforms enable final booking.

Multi-Platform Behavior

A recurring behavioral pattern across interviews is the use of **cross-platform decision workflows**. Rather than relying on a single application, users frequently move across multiple platforms before making a final choice.

For example, participants often described encountering a restaurant on social media and then switching to Yelp or Google Maps to verify ratings, distance, and operating hours (P1, P5, P9). Others begin with Google Maps to identify nearby options but then consult Yelp for deeper validation before deciding (P11, P12).

This fragmented workflow reflects a broader shift in digital consumer behavior. Restaurant discovery has become a distributed process, where different platforms specialize in different decision functions instead of providing an integrated experience.

Behavioral Gaps in Current Discovery Tools

Despite the availability of multiple discovery tools, interviews revealed several consistent behavioral gaps within the current ecosystem.

First, existing platforms often fail to capture **situational intent**. Most tools organize restaurants primarily by cuisine type, ratings, or popularity rather than the purpose of the visit. However, many interview participants described searching based on situational needs—such as finding a quiet café for studying, a quick meal after work, or a place suitable for group gatherings (P7, P10, P11). Because these contexts are not directly represented in platform filters, users must manually interpret whether a venue fits their situation.

Second, users frequently experience **decision fatigue** due to the large number of available options and limited contextual filtering. Large listings combined with minimal decision guidance make it difficult for users to narrow choices efficiently. This issue becomes particularly apparent in last-minute decision scenarios, where users want to reach a decision quickly rather than browse extensively.

Third, trust signals across platforms are often inconsistent. Participants expressed skepticism toward sponsored placements, overly promotional rankings, or recommendations that appear disconnected from their preferences (P1, P7, P9, P11, P12). When recommendations feel algorithmically opaque or commercially influenced, users tend to ignore them and rely instead on direct search or manual browsing.

Finally, the multi-platform nature of the ecosystem itself introduces friction. Because discovery, validation, and booking often occur on separate platforms, users must switch between applications to complete a single decision process.

Opportunity Zones

These behavioral gaps highlight several opportunities for new restaurant discovery platforms.

First, there is an opportunity to **reduce fragmented workflows** by integrating discovery and validation signals within a single interface. Second, platforms can differentiate themselves by introducing **context-aware discovery signals** that reflect real-life decision scenarios rather than only cuisine categories or ratings. Third, improving transparency around recommendation logic may increase trust and encourage users to engage with suggested venues.

A platform that successfully combines contextual discovery, trustworthy recommendations, and efficient filtering could significantly reduce the cognitive effort currently associated with restaurant decision-making.

Product Positioning SWOT

Based on the ecosystem analysis and interview insights, Voraa occupies a potential positioning niche focused on contextual discovery and decision efficiency.

Strengths	Weaknesses
• Context-driven discovery model emphasizing situational tags and behavioral signals • Potential to reduce multi-app workflows by integrating discovery and decision support • Focus on everyday dining scenarios rather than special occasions	• Limited venue coverage in early-stage markets • Lower brand recognition compared to established platforms such as Yelp and Google Maps • Early product friction (e.g., onboarding flow) identified in interviews
Opportunities	**Threats**
• Growing demand for faster decision-making tools that reduce choice overload • Increasing reliance on mobile discovery platforms among students and young professionals • Opportunity to bridge the gap between inspiration (social media) and validation (review platforms)	• Strong network effects of established platforms with large review databases • User habit inertia around Google Maps and Yelp • Difficulty scaling restaurant coverage quickly enough to maintain discovery value

Overall, Voraa's strategic positioning is not to replace infrastructure tools such as Google Maps or review platforms like Yelp, but rather to **optimize the decision layer of restaurant discovery**—helping users move from intent to choice more efficiently.

4.7 Behavioral segmentation

Interview results indicate that restaurant discovery behavior is not primarily differentiated by demographics but by decision style—how users approach choices, how quickly they want to decide, and what signals they rely on to reduce uncertainty. Based on recurring patterns across the interviews, four behavioral segments emerge.

Segment 1 — Quick Deciders

The first segment consists of Quick Deciders, users who open restaurant apps primarily to solve immediate decisions. These users often search for food after class or work and

prioritize proximity, speed, and minimal interaction with the interface. They tend to use search-first or map-first entry modes and have low tolerance for friction. If the app does not quickly surface relevant options within the first few minutes, they abandon it. Participants describing last-minute decisions after work or class strongly reflect this pattern (e.g., P11, P12, P9).

Segment 2 — Validation Seekers

A second segment consists of Validation Seekers, users who often arrive at the app with a candidate already in mind. Discovery may occur through social media, friends, or external browsing, while the app serves as a tool to confirm the decision through reviews, ratings, photos, or deal verification. These users are particularly sensitive to credibility signals and frequently distrust recommendations that appear sponsored or misaligned with their preferences (e.g., P1, P11, P12).

Segment 3 — Social Confirmers

The third segment consists of Social Confirmers, users who open restaurant discovery apps in group decision contexts. In these situations, the primary goal is not exploration but consensus. These users browse categories, compare a small set of options, and rely on ratings or filters to narrow the list quickly. This behavior appears frequently when participants describe situations where friends are deciding together but no one has a specific restaurant in mind (e.g., P4, P7, P8, P10, P12).

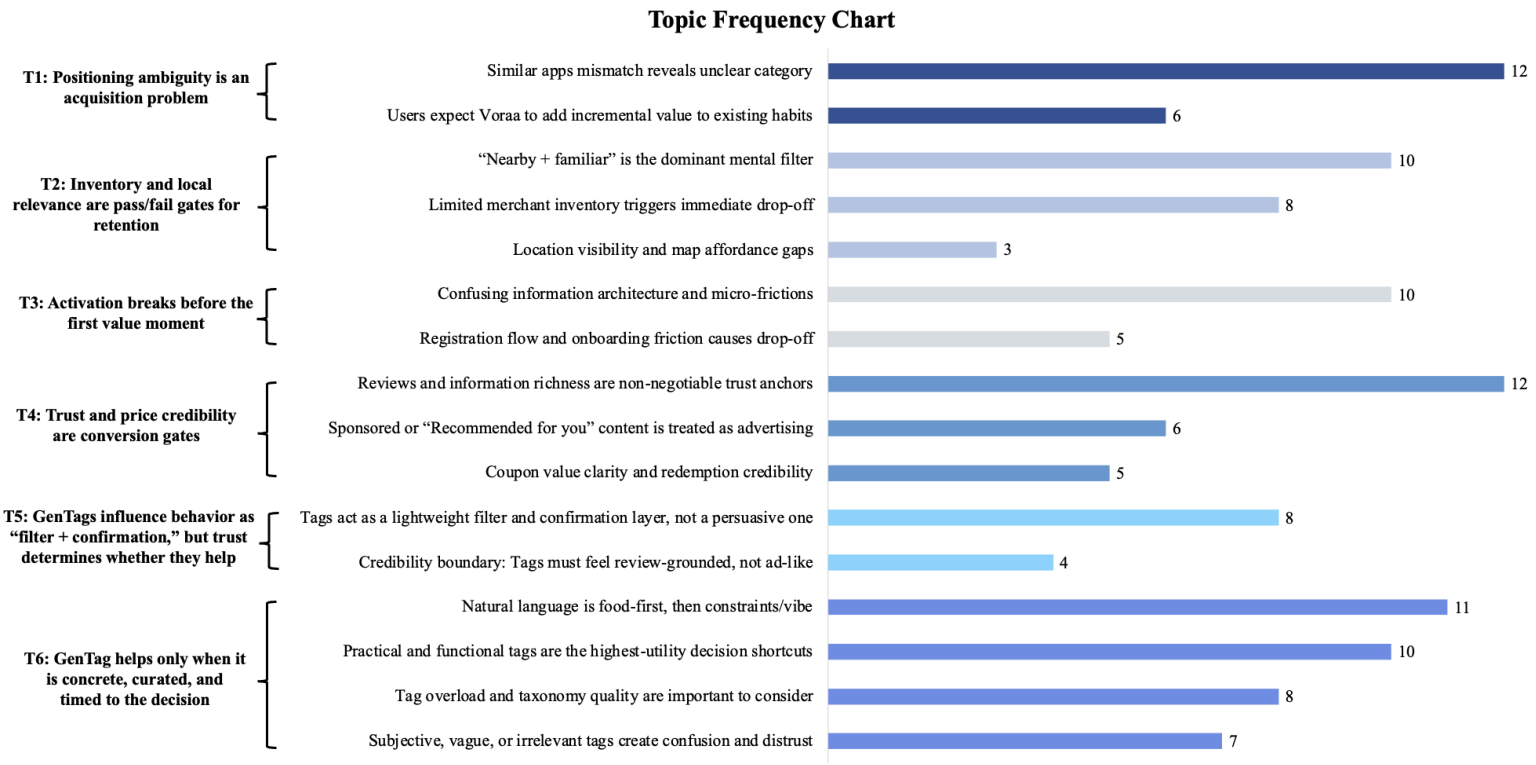
Segment 4 — Exploration Browsers

The fourth segment consists of Exploration Browsers, users who open restaurant apps without a predetermined target. Instead, they browse the feed or categories to see what is new or trending. These users are more receptive to recommendations and curated discovery experiences but still require strong signals of authenticity and variety to maintain engagement.

Across segments, one additional behavioral subtype appears consistently: **map-first walkability users**, particularly students without cars. These users open the map immediately to evaluate distance and walkability before considering other attributes (P10, P12). When the map lacks sufficient venue coverage, the experience quickly breaks down, creating immediate abandonment.

Overall, these segments reveal that restaurant discovery tools must optimize for multiple decision styles simultaneously. Some users prioritize speed and proximity, others seek validation and trust, while others want tools that facilitate group consensus or casual exploration. Understanding these behavioral patterns provides a strategic foundation for feature prioritization and product positioning within the Seattle market.

5. Key Findings and Insights



5.1 Positioning ambiguity is an acquisition problem (T1)

- **Finding statement:** Users cannot quickly anchor what Voraa is (deal app vs discovery vs reviews vs delivery), which weakens first-impression clarity and new-user conversion.
- **Why it matters:** If the category and "why use this over my current stack" is unclear, paid and organic acquisition will underperform and Day 0 churn will stay high.
- **Evidence:**
  - *"I've used Google Maps and DoorDash, and I only use Yelp occasionally. I haven't really used a coupon-based app before, though, so that part of the experience was pretty new to me."* (Participant 1)
  - *"Most of the time, I already have a short mental list of places I'd be okay with, so I just scan the feed to see if any of those places show up with a deal."* (Participant 2)
  - *"The two similar applications that I can think of are, uh, Too Good2Go and Yelp."* (Participant 5)
  - *"Yes. Xiaohongshu (Rednote)."* (Participant 6)

- *"Yes, I've used apps like Yelp, Google Maps, and occasionally Instagram to look up places."* (Participant 12)

- **Who it affects:** New users and light users deciding whether Voraa is worth adding to their existing app routine.
- **Opportunity:** Clarify Voraa's market positioning around its differentiator: *find a real deal fast and redeem it easily.*
- **Design implication:** Tighten onboarding and home information architecture around one primary task: **find a real deal fast and redeem it easily**. Clearly label secondary modes such as discover and verify, and remove cross-category cues that make Voraa feel unfocused or like "a little bit of everything."
- **Priority: P0**
- **Success metrics:**
  - sign-up completion rate
  - new-user activation rate
  - Day 0 to Day 1 retention

<u>Segment differences</u>

- Students are more likely to interpret Voraa through a savings lens.
- Working professionals frame value through time/convenience rather than coupons alone.

5.2 Inventory and local relevance are pass/fail gates for retention (T2)

- **Finding statement:** Users abandon Voraa quickly when they cannot find enough relevant venues near where they actually live and spend time.
- **Why it matters:** For a local two-sided marketplace, low perceived local coverage prevents the first value moment and blocks repeat behavior, which directly caps retention and revenue.
- **Evidence:**
  - *"I'd stop very early if the store inventory doesn't match my reality. If the app doesn't include the places I already go to or would consider going to, there's no reason for me to keep browsing."* (Participant 2)
  - *"In Seattle, the store coverage feels limited right now. Even though some discounts are attractive, if I can't find places I want to eat regularly, I won't come back often."* (Participant 3)

- *"If I cannot find a place I want for about 10 mins, I would stop using it."* (Participant 4)
- *"Only 5 places?"* (Participant 6)
- *"I first navigate to the map, however, it shows there are no venues in the place where I live. I have to navigate back to home for finding venues. For student who doesn't have a car. Location and distance is something I care about. And that's why I navigate to map for finding venues."* (Participant 10)

- **Who it affects:** Everyone.
- **Opportunity:** Treat "Seattle local density" as a core product requirement and address the chicken-and-egg problem from the merchant side by prioritizing supply onboarding before scaling user acquisition.
- **Design implication:** Align product strategy and early experience around the reality of local supply: **onboard supply first, then scale users.** If early users perceive sparse, low-value inventory, they won't return.
- **Priority: P0**
- **Success metrics:**
  - inventory coverage growth rate in Seattle
  - local merchant density
  - early exit rate from map sessions

Negative cases

Some users will still use Voraa as a "coupon layer" even if proof lives elsewhere (external workflow). This implies Voraa can still win with partial value if the deal layer is strong, but coverage still limits frequency.

Segment differences

- This pattern is more common among students due to walkability constraints. They operate in a tighter radius and depend heavily on local density.
- Professionals show higher distance tolerance but still require local relevance.

5.3 Activation breaks before the first value moment (T3)

- **Finding statement:** Users hit friction before experiencing value, including unskippable onboarding, bugs, cluttered UI, and repeated interruptions.
- **Why it matters:** Every extra step before value reduces new-user conversion and reinforces "I'll just go back to my usual apps," lowering both acquisition efficiency and retention.

- **Evidence:**
    - *"Honestly, the new user registration flow was rough. Choosing my birthday wasn't convenient, and the "How did you hear about Voraa?" question felt unnecessary. I also didn't like that I couldn't skip it. When I clicked back because I was hesitating, all my previous info disappeared. That's such a bad feeling, like the app just wasted my time.*

      And another thing: I picked "Other," typed in "school project," and then the Continue button just didn't work. That made me feel stuck.

      Overall, there are just too many required steps. I'd want it to be simpler, more skippable, and to save my progress if I go back." (Participant 1)
    - *"When I click on the search bar in the search tab, and I lose focus of the search bar the keyboard does not disappear. I have to manually click on "done" to continue."* (Participant 6)
    - *"It needs a more concise and clear display interface and function guidance. For example, I think the homepage could be simpler; it currently looks a bit cluttered and overly flashy."* (Participant 7)
    - *"I'd prefer a more transparent and achievable onboarding experience, like gradually unlocking features or rewards through normal usage."* (Participant 11)
    - *"I'd want a simpler onboarding. Maybe just show me nearby places first and let me explore before asking me to do anything complicated."* (Participant 12)
- **Who it affects:** New users encountering the product for the first time.
- **Opportunity:** Move value earlier and reduce "work before reward" by proactively fixing recurring system and UI issues that disrupt flow and undermine confidence.
- **Design implication:** Let users browse first and defer sign-up until just before redeem. Make registration more flexible, preserve in-progress actions, and aggressively eliminate recurring UI bugs and friction points that interrupt navigation
- **Priority: P1**
- **Success metrics:**
    - sign-up completion rate
    - new-user activation rate
    - session crash rate

<u>Negative cases</u>

Notably, friction is not just about "forms." The onboarding challenge felt unrealistic and made the app seem untrustworthy. This suggests some activation issues are trust-damaging growth mechanics, not merely UX length.

5.4 Trust and price credibility are conversion gates (T4)

- **Finding statement:** Users hesitate to click, claim, or redeem when recommendations feel sponsored and when coupons feel conditional or unclear; reviews and rich information are required to reduce perceived risk.
- **Why it matters:** Monetization requires claim and redeem. Trust gaps reduce conversion, and they also undermine the effectiveness of retention because users do not come back.
- **Evidence (2–4):**
    - *"The second issue is the lack of reviews. For some restaurants, there just isn't enough information to know whether they're worth trying."* (Participant 3)
    - *"If the pictures don't reflect the actual food at the restaurant, I'll be less interested in the restaurant."* (Participant 4)
    - *"The coupon is fake like you have to pay more money than it said."* (Participant 7)
    - *"Recommendations sometimes are sponsored. Like the top few choices Amazon shopping will give you when you search for a product."* (Participant 9)
    - *"I don't trust them when they feel sponsored, overly generic, or disconnected from my past behavior. If the photos don't look realistic or ratings feel inflated, I'll ignore them."* (Participant 11)
- **Who it affects:** Users who require proof before trying a venue on Voraa, and users who are sensitive to "sponsored" cues or hidden coupon conditions.
- **Opportunity:** Win trust through transparency, proof, and straightforward deal presentation.
- **Design implication:** Make review/ratings and key details visible where decisions happen, clearly label sponsorship (if any), show clear deal math (before vs after), and remove surprise paywalls or explain them upfront.
- **Priority: P1**
- **Success metrics:**
    - claim rate per venue detail view
    - redeem rate per claim

- return rate after first redemption

Negative cases

Notably, some users prefer external proof and are OK leaving the app for reviews. This suggests Voraa can prioritize *minimum viable trust signals* now, while deeper review integration can be phased.

Segment differences

- Male users care more about algorithmic credibility and "how it works" transparency in the recommendations.
- Female users emphasize social proof visibility (reviews presence and volume) as a conversion requirement.

5.5 GenTags influence behavior as "filter + confirmation," but trust determines whether they help (T5)

- **Finding statement:** Tags rarely persuade on their own; they work when they help users filter faster and confirm a choice, but they lose value when they conflict with evidence or feel promotional.
- **Why it matters:** GenTags can reduce decision friction and support conversion, but only if users trust them. Otherwise, they become noise and may reduce confidence.
- **Evidence:**
  - *"And if the app doesn't have reviews, then tags become even more important, because they carry the platform's credibility."* (Participant 2)
  - *"Tags are mostly supporting information for me. They help filter and confirm choices, but they don't replace reviews."* (Participant 3)
  - *"If it has too many tags or the tags show different with the reviews (then tags might make choosing harder or more confusing)."* (Participant 7)
  - *"I prefer tags extracted from the reviews. If the tags include 'bad service' or 'high tips', I will just stop wasting time and looking for another place."* (Participant 9)
  - *"I kinda have an answer before I go into this application. The tag is just confirming my choice."* (Participant 10)
- **Who it affects:** Users who use tags as decision shortcuts to narrow choices, confirm fit, or rule out options.
- **Opportunity:** Position tags as decision-support, grounded in evidence, not as marketing copy.

- **Design implication:** Tie tags to review language or observable signals where possible, allow negative/exclusion tags, and ensure tags appear at the exact decision points where they reduce effort.
- **Priority: P1**
- **Success metrics:**
    - tag interaction rate
    - time-to-decision on venue detail
    - mismatch complaints rate

Negative cases

Notably, tags are not only a form of "positive confirmation." They can also help users make decisions more efficiently by ruling options out. This suggests that "disqualifying" tags may be disproportionately valuable.

Segment differences

- This pattern is more common among male users as exclusion filters and verification tools.
- Female users show more openness to exploration, so tags can support "try something new" if credibility is strong.

5.6 GenTag helps only when it is concrete, curated, and timed to the decision (T6)

- **Finding statement:** Users think food-first, then refine by constraints and context; practical, specific tags help, while vague/subjective, irrelevant, or excessive tags confuse and reduce trust.
- **Why it matters:** Tag design directly affects browsing efficiency and perceived quality of recommendations, influencing click, claim, and revisit behavior.
- **Evidence:**
    - *"Too many tags are overwhelming. I'd rather see only the top 3–5 tags that are personalized to me."* (Participant 2)
    - *"Feel like the Tag should be mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive (MECE), which means there should not be overlapped tags."* (Participant 4)
    - *"Food type probably matters most."* (Participant 5)

    - *"Tags like "good for studying" could be helpful, but vague words like "good" or "cozy" alone do not clearly describe a place. I prefer tags with specific meaning."* (Participant 8)
    - *"Practical features are more helpful because they help me avoid places that won't work for what I need."* (Participant 12)

- **Who it affects:** Everyone.
- **Opportunity:** Use GenTag to shorten the path from intent to a confident choice.
- **Design implication:** Prioritize a small set of high-utility functional tags, keep vibe tags specific and situational, enforce a clean taxonomy (limit overlap), and integrate tags into filters rather than only as decoration.
- **Priority: P0**
- **Success metrics:**
    - filter usage rate
    - decision time per session
    - hide/dismiss tag actions

<u>Segment differences</u>

- Students value tabs with tight constraints (walkability, study contexts) and high reliance on practical fit.
- Professionals prioritize convenience and may value tags like parking or time-saving cues more than vibe.

6. Journey Map and Flow Pain Points

6.1 Current journey map

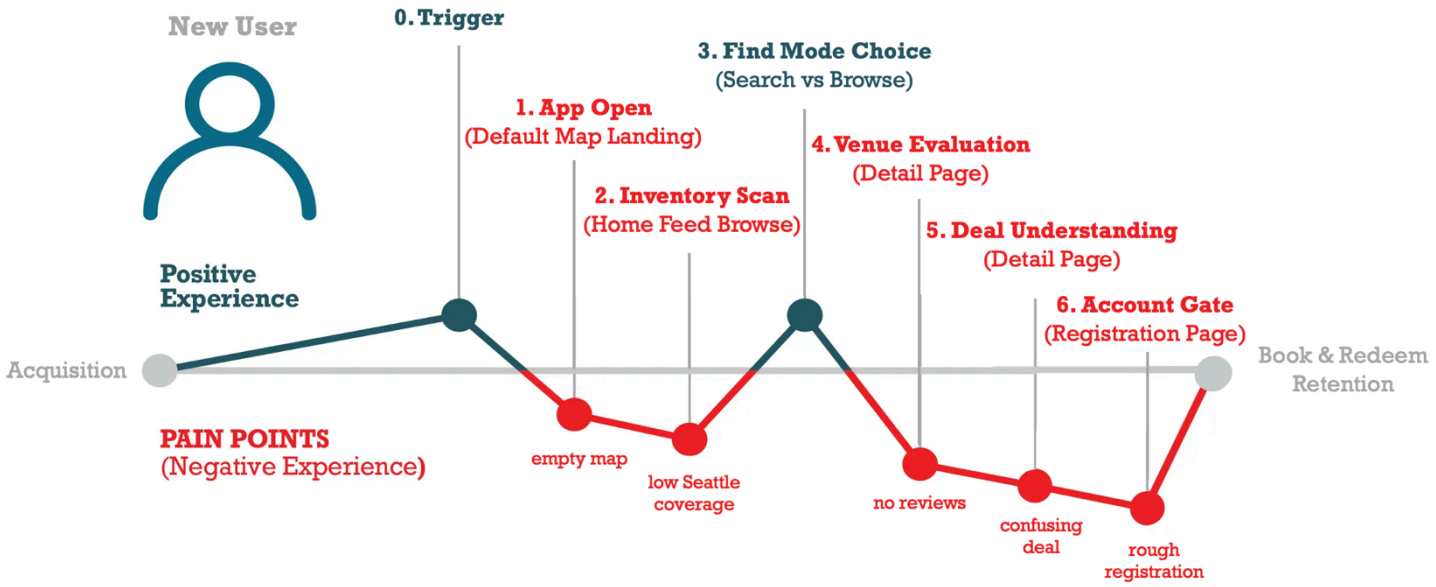
Based on the recurring usage situations and app entry modes identified earlier, we translate interview findings into an end-to-end journey map that reflects how Seattle users actually move from intent to action. This map highlights the key decision points, common breakdowns, and the moments where missing inventory, weak credibility signals, or early flow friction most often push users to abandon the experience.

Seattle New User Journey Map

Stage	User goal	Touchpoints	Key questions	Friction points	Emotion (L/M/H)	What to improve
0. Trigger	Decide where to eat, ideally fast & good value	App icon, expectation set by "deals/perks" framing	*"Will this help me decide faster and get better deals than other Apps?"*	If the app feels ad-like or misleading, users are ready to bounce quickly.	L	Prop the ***"fast and real deal"*** unmistakable in the first 10s.
1. App opens & first orientation	Understand "what am I looking at" and whether it's usable in Seattle	Default landing (Map), bottom tabs, first screen content	*"Why is this map empty?"* *"Is this broken or just low supply?"*	Empty map = confusion and immediate trust hit.	H	Treat "empty state" as a first-class experience: **explain local coverage reality clearly**
2. Inventory scan (Home feed browse)	Quickly see if there are enough relevant options	Home feed, category tabs, scrolling list	*"Do I see places I'd actually go to?"* *"Is there enough choice?"*	Low Seattle coverage makes browsing end fast.	H	**Supply-first strategy** for Seattle: ensure density in a few neighborhoods before scaling acquisition
3. Find mode choice (Search vs Browse vs Map)	Use their natural habit: many are task-driven (search), others browse	Search bar, filters, category tabs, map	*"Can I search what I already want?"* *"Can I filter by real categories?"*	If search is limited and filters are week, user experience hurts.	L	**Tighten the *"find"* experience** around 1–2 primary modes that match real intent (search-first and nearby-first).

4. **Venue evaluation (detail page)**	Reduce risk enough to click/claim	Venue detail page, photos, key info, tags, reviews	*"Is this place legit?"* *"Is it worth trying?"*	Lack of reviews increases uncertainty and hesitancy.	H	Don't force Voraa to "rebuild Yelp," but ensure users can **access credibility signals** without bouncing.
5. **Deal understanding (perk / happy hour / coupon)**	Understand deal value fast and trust redemption	Deal module, perk CTA, happy hour items	*"What's the actual savings?"* *"Any hidden conditions?"* *"Can I really redeem?"*	Deal math is inconsistent/confusing. "Fake coupon" is a hard stop.	H	**Standardize deal presentation and key conditions** up front to avoid bait-and-switch perception.
6. **Account gate (sign up / log in)**	Get access with minimal "work before reward"	Phone entry, birthday picker, "how did you hear about…"	*"Why do I need this now?"* *"Will I lose my progress?"*	Registration flow is rough, unskippable; going back can wipe info; cannot "Continue".	H	Defer sign-up until just before claim/redeem; **preserve progress and remove brittle steps.**
7. **Post-action retention hooks**	Decide whether to return	Save/Been, profile, subscriptions, referrals	*"Why keep this app?"* *"Is premium worth it here?"*	Premium/referrals /gamification feel disconnected from value with the thin inventory in Seattle.	M	Earn retention by **solving fundamentals first.**

Voraa User Journey Map - Seattle Market



6.2 Top friction points

The following table prioritizes friction points by severity, frequency, and expected impact. Critical items should be addressed before broader Seattle market launch.

Prioritized Friction Points

Pain Point	Where in Flow	Severity	Frequency	Expected Impact	Suggested Fix
Limited Seattle restaurant inventory	All stages	H	H	Immediate early churn	1. Aggressive venue onboarding; 2. Focus on high-traffic areas; 3. Show “Coming Soon” venues
Registration flow breaks and loses data	Decision Point	H	H	Conversion drops at sign-up gate	1. Implement form state persistence; 2. Make fields optional
Map shows no restaurants	Discovery & First Impression	M	H	Broken-first-impression; early exits	1. Land on Home tab; 2. Add banner: *“We're growing in Seattle!”*
Zero reviews available	Restaurant Evaluation	M	H	Higher decision risk; lower claim intent	1. Import external reviews via API; 2. Incentivize early user reviews

Category filters not MECE	Exploration & Understanding	M	H	Lower findability; slower discovery	1. Redesign category filters as hierarchical
Gamification feels dishonest	Exploration & Understanding	M	M	Trust erosion; reduced engagement	1. Replace with achievable progressive challenges; 2. Add clear rules and win rate stats
Coupon display inconsistency	Restaurant Evaluation	M	M	Value confusion; lower claim confidence	1. Create standard template: show original price, discount, and final price side-by-side
Walkthrough video easy to miss	Exploration & Understanding	L	M	Slower onboarding; lower feature adoption	1. Show modal on first app open; 2. Add help icon in header; 3. Offer text guide alternative
Premium without value proposition with limited inventory	Retention	L	L	Upsell friction; weaker retention signals	1. Delay premium upsell until more venues 2. Offer “early adopter” pricing lock

7. GenTag: Understanding, Trust, and Behavioral Impact

GenTags are most valuable when they function as **decision support**, not persuasion. Across interviews, users treat tags as a lightweight layer that helps them **filter faster** and **confirm fit**, but tags can quickly lose value if they feel promotional, subjective, or inconsistent with evidence. Negative cases and segment splits add nuance: some users use tags primarily to **disqualify** options, and trust expectations differ by gender and by student vs working-professional contexts.

7.1 User understanding and language

Mental models

Users implicitly place tags into three mental buckets:

- **Intent and category anchors (food-first)**
    - Users start with cuisine or dish, then refine with constraints or vibe.
    - Tags are expected to support this flow, not compete with it.
- **Practical constraint shortcuts**
    - High-utility tags reduce effort by ruling out non-starters quickly (price, Wi-Fi, outlets, seating, distance, parking).
- **Evidence-backed summaries**
    - Many users assume credible tags should be grounded in reviews or observable signals. When reviews are missing, tags become even more responsible for credibility.

Common misunderstandings

- **Tags as marketing claims:** Users distrust tags when they feel like copywriting or exaggeration.
- **Tags as "the truth" without evidence:** If tags conflict with what users see (photos, menus, reviews), users treat tags as unreliable.
- **"Positive-only tags" assumption:** A negative case shows tags are also used to dismiss options quickly. This implies disqualifying tags can be disproportionately valuable for decision speed.

Vocabulary mapping

Below is a practical mapping to reduce "translation friction" between how users talk and how the product tags things.

What users say	What they mean	GenTag wording recommendation	Notes
"Chinese" "brunch" "coffee" "Sushi"	Food-first intent	Keep cuisine and meal types as primary anchors	Avoid mixing meal-time and cuisine in the same level without structure
"Near me" "walkable" "around U District"	Distance and neighborhood	"Within X min walk" "Near [Neighborhood]"	Especially critical for students without cars
"Not too expensive" "cheap" "deal"	Price constraint	"$" "$$" plus "Typical entrée $X–$Y" if possible	Users want fast value judgement, not vague labels
"Good for studying" "quiet" "outlets"	Functional needs	"Outlets available" "Quiet" "Study-friendly"	Prefer measurable or verifiable signals
"Too noisy" "bad service" "high tips"	Disqualifiers	"Often noisy" "Service complaints"	Disqualifying tags should be neutral and evidence-based
"Feels sponsored" "recommended is ad"	Skepticism to promotion	Avoid salesy tag tone, clearly label sponsorship	Users interpret ambiguous recommendation language as ads

7.2 Trust and interpretability requirements

Users do not trust tags simply because they exist. Tags gain credibility when they:

- **Evidence grounding**
  - Users prefer tags derived from review language or observable signals.
  - When reviews are missing, tags must not overclaim certainty.
- **Consistency with evidence**
  - Tags must match what users can verify via photos, menus, or external proof.
- **Non-promotional tone**
  - Users are highly sensitive to sponsored cues. When content feels paid or generic, they discount it.

A negative case highlights that some users distrust recommendations based on bad experiences across other apps. This means Voraa must earn trust through **differentiated and transparent logic: explainability.** Explainability helps users understand relevance about why this recommendation appears, what it matches, and what evidence supports it.

Segment nuance from data partitioning further reveals:

- **Male users:** more likely to value algorithmic transparency and controllability. They want to know why something is shown and whether it is influenced by paid placement.
- **Female users:** rely more heavily on reviews and information richness.
- **Students:** typically more price-sensitive and walkability-constrained. Practical tags tied to nearby and affordability reduce effort.
- **Working professionals:** more sensitive to hidden conditions and paywalls. They need straightforward terms and fast validation.

Implication: the same tag system needs different emphasis by segment, but the credibility rule stays constant: tags must feel grounded, not salesy.

7.3 Tag presentation guidelines

- **Principle 1: Keep tags scannable:** Default to **3 to 5 tags** on key surfaces. Treat everything beyond that as secondary, available via expand, not auto-shown.
- **Principle 2: Use a clear hierarchy:** Always prioritize: cuisine or dish anchor, then 1 to 2 practical constraints (distance, price, Wi-Fi, seating, parking). Keep vibe and long-tail tags secondary unless the user explicitly asks for them.
- **Principle 3: Make disqualifying tags usable:** Disqualifying tags should exist, but must be neutral and evidence-backed, not judgmental. They should help users exit a bad fit without abandoning the app.
- **Principle 4: Show tags at decision points:** Do not treat tags as decoration. Place them where they reduce effort. Tags matter most when users decide whether to:
    - click into a venue
    - claim a deal
    - follow through to redeem.
- **Principle 5: Build user control and feedback**: To improve trust and recommendation quality over time, add lightweight controls:
    - “More like this” and “Less like this”
    - Hide or block a tag
    - “Tag is inaccurate” feedback
    - One-tap exclusion filters for efficiency users

8. Recommendations and Prioritization

8.1 Recommendation 1 — Establish a single “deal-first” default journey

- **Prioritization:** P0
- **Targeted problem:** New users cannot quickly anchor what Voraa is, so they churn on Day 0.
- **Scope:** Clarify positioning around “find a real deal fast and redeem easily”; change the default landing to Home, not Map.
- **Dependencies:** Product + design alignment; engineering support.
- **Metric to monitor:**
    - sign-up completion rate
    - new-user activation rate
    - Day 0 to Day 1 retention

8.2 Recommendation 2 — Enforce a Seattle density threshold before scaling acquisition

- **Prioritization:** P0
- **Targeted problem:** Users leave quickly when inventory is thin or not locally relevant.
- **Scope:** Supply-first Seattle strategy: focus merchant onboarding in a few high-traffic neighborhoods to create visible density before scaling acquisition; align acquisition targeting to covered areas.
- **Dependencies:** Merchant partnerships and onboarding capacity; neighborhood selection.
- **Metric to monitor:**
    - inventory coverage growth rate in Seattle
    - local merchant density
    - early exit rate from map sessions

8.3 Recommendation 3 — Harden registration and fix recurring micro-frictions that break task flow

- **Prioritization:** P0
- **Targeted problem:** Users lose trust and drop during registration and early exploration due to unskippable fields, lost progress, and recurring UI bugs that interrupt navigation.
- **Scope:** Improve early-session reliability by hardening registration state handling, simplifying or making optional low-value fields, and fixing recurring high-visibility UI bugs that interrupt browsing and search.
- **Dependencies:** Engineering + QA capacity; analytics event instrumentation.
- **Metric to monitor:**
    - sign-up error rate
    - session crash rate
    - task interruption rate

8.4 Recommendation 4 — Establish conversion credibility and streamline "validate + book" pathways

- **Prioritization:** P1
- **Targeted problem:** Users hesitate to click, claim, redeem, or book when venues lack proof and when deal value feels inconsistent or conditional. In addition, many users switch to other platforms (Google/Yelp/OpenTable) for validation and booking, which increases drop-off.
- **Scope:** Implement a single credibility and conversion standard on every venue detail and deal surface by: (1) ensuring users can see a reliable proof signal at decision time (review/ratings integration via API or a clearly labeled external proof workflow), (2) standardizing deal presentation with redemption constraints and any paywalls disclosed upfront, and (3) making booking a clear, low-friction next step when relevant (native booking if available, otherwise clean deep links to reservation partners).
- **Dependencies:** Review strategy and data access (integration partner/API or external proof workflow); booking integration or deep-link strategy; design system standards; analytics event instrumentation.
- **Metric to monitor:**
    - venue detail → booking click-through rate
    - claim and redeem rate per venue detail view
    - return rate after first redemption

8.5 Recommendation 5 — Make GenTags a curated "decision toolkit" with evidence cues and user control

- **Prioritization:** P1
- **Targeted problem:** Tags help users filter and confirm, but lose value when they feel promotional, overload users, or conflict with evidence; some users need disqualifying tags to rule out options quickly.
- **Scope:** Show 3-5 personalized high-utility tags (food-first + practical constraints) by default; ground tags in observable signals or review language; add disqualifying and exclusion tags; provide user controls (hide, less like this, not relevant, inaccurate).
- **Dependencies:** Stable user ID + event tracking; tag taxonomy cleanup; preference/ranking model; evidence source selection; instrumentation for feedback loops.
- **Metric to monitor:**
    - tag interaction rate
    - filter usage rate
    - time-to-decision on venue detail

8.6 Recommendation 6 — Build a "Find fast" layer aligned with entry modes (Search-first, Browse-first, Map-first)

- **Prioritization:** P0
- **Targeted problem:** Users enter with different decision modes (search-first, browse-first, map-first), but Voraa does not consistently support fast narrowing, which increases early confusion and abandonment.
- **Scope:** Make "Find" a first-class experience by supporting the three dominant entry modes with clear paths:
    - **Search-first:** robust keyword search (venue, cuisine, dish) with autocomplete.
    - **Browse-first:** clean category hierarchy and a short set of high-utility filters.
    - **Map-first:** reliable proximity view with strong empty-state handling and "open now / walkable" defaults.

Introduce a lightweight **Deal-breaker filter set** (distance, open now, price/deal, category) to reduce decision space early.

- **Dependencies:** Search and filtering implementation; venue metadata readiness (hours, price/deal, category); instrumentation for usage funnels.
- **Metric to monitor:**

- search usage and success rate (search → venue view)
- filter usage rate
- Time-to-first-relevant-venue

9. Appendices

9.1 Interview guide

Interview Duration:20-30 minutes

Interviewee Exploration of the App: 5-10 mins

User Persona :

Age:

Gender:

Profession:

Warmup questions:

Have you ever used any application like this? If yes, what are they?

Part 1 — Usage Scenarios & Trust in Recommendations

Goal: Understand when/why users open these kinds of apps and whether they trust recommendations.

1. In what situations do you usually open an app to decide where to go?
   (Hint: Alone, with friends, last-minute, planned ahead, work/study, travel, etc.)
2. When you open an app, what's usually the first thing you do?
   (Hint: Browse home feed, search, click categories, ask friends, etc.)
3. When apps show "Recommended for you" or similar suggestions, do you usually click them? Why / why not?
4. Are there situations when you don't trust recommendations? Can you give an example?
   (Hint: Pictures are not appealing, ratings are low, etc.)
5. What usually makes you stop using an app like this, or drop off after trying it once or twice? What usually motivates you to try a new app like this?

Part 2 — Voraa Interaction and Flow Pain Points

Goal: Identify the most obvious blockers and drop-off points during the Voraa experience to inform UI and feature improvements.

1. What was the biggest thing that hurt your experience while using the app?

   (Hint: annoying layout, confusing next step, slow loading, unclear labels, repetitive inputs)

   - If we changed it to match your habits, what would you want instead?

2. Were there any features you expected the app to have, but couldn't find?

   (Hint: search, filters/sort, save/favorites, history, map view, sharing, "why this recommendation")

3. If you were using this on your own, where would you be most likely to stop and leave? Why?

   (Hint: onboarding/sign-in, first task, irrelevant results, long flow, no clear payoff)

   - On the flip side, what did the app do well that would make you want to keep using it?

   (Hint: fast to complete tasks, helpful recommendations, feel personalized)

4. On a scale of 1–10, how confident did you feel using the app without any help? Why that score?

Part 3 — GenTag: Understanding & Language use

Goal: Determine whether GenTags make sense to users as a way of describing and understanding places.

1. When you're looking for a new restaurant or café, how do you usually describe what you're looking for? (Cuisine-wise, purpose-wise, or other)
2. Do you tend to think more in terms of food type, or in terms of vibe or situation (for example: quiet, cozy, good for studying)?
3. If you were recommending a place to a friend, what kinds of words would you use to describe it?
4. Do you feel these tags describe more:
   a. Practical features (outlets, seating, space), or
   b. Overall atmosphere and feeling?
5. Which of those is more helpful to you when deciding where to go, and why?

6. If a place has many tags, does that make it clearer—or does it start to feel overwhelming?

Part 4 — GenTag: Behavioral & Decision Impact

Goal: Understand whether GenTags *actually change user behavior*—decision speed, choice, and willingness to explore new venues—not whether users simply like them.

1. If you saw descriptive tags like *quiet*, *cozy*, or *good for studying* when browsing places, would you decide where to go faster? (Hint: faster, easier, less overwhelming)
    - Would they help you rule out options more quickly, or would they just be nice to have, without changing much?
2. Would these tags ever change which place you choose? (Hint: Tags as decision drivers vs. decision validators; Whether tags influence final choice)
    - Could you imagine choosing a different place because of a tag?
    - Do tags feel more like they persuade you, or confirm what you already want?
3. If a place you've never been to had these tags, would you be more likely to click or try it? (Hint: Reduced uncertainty; Increased willingness to explore underutilized venues)
    - Why or why not?
    - Do the tags make the place feel less risky or more familiar?
4. For you, do these tags feel more like: a way to quickly filter options, a way to confirm a decision, or just extra information? (Hint: Primary role of GenTags in the user journey; Whether tags should be prominent or secondary)
    - If you could only show tags in one place, where would they be most helpful?
5. Is there any situation where these tags might make choosing harder or more confusing? (Hint: Cognitive overload; Trust issues)
    - Too many tags?
    - Too subjective or unclear?

9.2 Codebook

Theme 1 (T1): Positioning ambiguity is an acquisition problem

- **Theme definition:** Users compare Voraa to very different app categories, indicating unclear product category and value proposition.
- **Business rationale:** If users can't answer "what is this app for?" quickly, acquisition efficiency drops and early churn increases.

Codes under T1

T1-C1 "Similar apps" mismatch reveals unclear category

- **Definition:** Users reference very different existing apps (maps, reviews, delivery, social discovery, deal apps), indicating unclear product category and value proposition.
- **Rationale:** Signals positioning confusion, lowering first-impression clarity and conversion.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"I've used Google Maps and DoorDash, and I only use Yelp occasionally. I haven't really used a coupon-based app before, though, so that part of the experience was pretty new to me."* (Participant 1)
  - *"Xiaohongshu (Rednote)."* (Participant 6)
  - *"The two similar applications that I can think of are, uh, Too Good2Go and Yelp."* (Participant 5)

T1-C2 Users expect Voraa to add incremental value to existing habits

- **Definition:** Users won't replace existing apps; they want Voraa to make decisions faster or cheaper.
- **Rationale:** Acquisition messaging and product prioritization should focus on the incremental edge.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"So when I tried this app, I actually felt the purpose made sense. It's clearly about helping people save money on food, which I care about."* (Participant 3)
  - *"Usually I already know what kind of food I want. I'll first check other social media for recommendations, and then I open an app like Voraa to look up details, like the menu, and whether there are any deals or discounts."* (Participant 1)

- *"Most of the time, I already have a short mental list of places I'd be okay with, so I just scan the feed to see if any of those places show up with a deal."* (Participant 2)

Theme 2 (T2) Inventory and local relevance are pass/fail gates for retention

- **Theme definition:** Users quickly abandon Voraa when nearby, relevant, or familiar merchant options are missing. For a local marketplace, perceived usefulness is tightly coupled to inventory density in the target area.
- **Business rationale:** Low inventory density undermines first-session success (cannot find something to use), which reduces repeat usage and blocks retention growth.

Codes under T2

T2-C1 Limited merchant inventory triggers immediate drop-off

- **Definition:** Users leave early when they cannot find enough appealing, relevant venues; inventory density is a prerequisite for value.
- **Rationale:** Inventory is a prerequisite for habit formation and repeat usage in a local app.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Only 5 places?"* (Participant 6)
  - *"What would make me stop using it is if there are too few merchants. In Seattle, the store coverage feels limited right now. Even though some discounts are attractive, if I can't find places I want to eat regularly, I won't come back often."* (Participant 3)
  - *"If I cannot find a place I want for about 10 mins, I would stop using it."* (Participant 4)

T2-C2 "Nearby + familiar" is the dominant mental filter

- **Definition:** Users evaluate usefulness through proximity, convenience, and whether venues match their real routines and familiar places.
- **Rationale:** If users cannot quickly see "places I would actually go," acquisition and retention both stall.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"I'd want more merchants onboarded, especially around areas where people like me live or spend time, like university districts. That would also make pickup more realistic if delivery isn't available."* (Participant 3)

- *"I'd stop very early if the store inventory doesn't match my reality. If the app doesn't include the places I already go to or would consider going to, there's no reason for me to keep browsing."* (Participant 2)
- *"I first navigate to the map, however, it shows there are no venues in the place where I live. I have to navigate back to home for finding venues. For student who doesn't have a car. Location and distance is something I care about. And that's why I navigate to map for finding venues."* (Participant 10)

T2-C3 Location visibility and map affordance gaps

- **Definition:** Users cannot reliably judge where venues are or how far they are due to missing or broken map/location affordances.
- **Rationale:** Breaks core decision logic for Seattle users, especially walkability constraints.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"When you search something in the engine, you can't see the result on the map inside the app, the only way to see where it is to use the google map button and jump to another app."* (Participant 9)
  - *"Map view is not available when I click on certain spots and I want to see how far I am to this place."* (Participant 6)

Theme 3 (T3): Activation breaks before the first value moment

- **Theme definition:** Early-session barriers prevent users from reaching a first "value moment", lowering Day 0 success and repeat intent.
- **Business rationale:** Directly impacts new user acquisition conversion and D1 retention.

Codes under T3

T3-C1 Registration flow and onboarding friction causes drop-off

- **Definition:** Sign-up and onboarding steps feel long, unskippable, or error-prone, preventing users from reaching a first value moment.
- **Rationale:** Users abandon before reaching value, harming both acquisition conversion and retention.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Honestly, the new user registration flow was rough. Choosing my birthday wasn't convenient, and the "How did you hear about Voraa?" question felt unnecessary. I also didn't like that I couldn't skip it. When I clicked back because I was hesitating, all my previous info disappeared. That's such a bad feeling, like the app just wasted my time.*

And another thing: I picked "Other," typed in "school project," and then the Continue button just didn't work. That made me feel stuck.

Overall, there are just too many required steps. I'd want it to be simpler, more skippable, and to save my progress if I go back." (Participant 1)

- *"I'd prefer a more transparent and achievable onboarding experience, like gradually unlocking features or rewards through normal usage."* (Participant 11)
- *"I'd want a simpler onboarding. Maybe just show me nearby places first and let me explore before asking me to do anything complicated."* (Participant 12)

T3-C2 Confusing information architecture and micro-frictions

- **Definition:** Clutter, unclear structure, small interaction bugs, and interruptions break task flow and reduce confidence.
- **Rationale:** Adds "hidden cost" to exploration and undermines repeat usage.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"When I click on the search bar in the search tab, and I lose focus of the search bar the keyboard does not disappear. I have to manually click on "done" to continue."* (Participant 6)
  - *"It needs a more concise and clear display interface and function guidance. For example, I think the homepage could be simpler; it currently looks a bit cluttered and overly flashy."* (Participant 7)
  - *"The functions always have some bugs and you have to reopen the app many times."* (Participant 7)

Theme 4 (T4): Trust and price credibility are conversion gates

- **Theme definition:** Users treat the experience as risky if recommendations feel sponsored or coupons feel conditional, limiting claim and redeem.
- **Business rationale:** Trust is required for clicks, claims, and ultimately retention. Weak credibility signals cause abandonment and reduce acquisition efficiency

Codes under T4

T4-C1 Sponsored or "Recommended for you" content is treated as advertising

- **Definition:** Users discount recommendations when they suspect paid placement or generic promotion, reducing exploration and conversion.
- **Rationale:** If recommendations read as ads, they do not drive exploration, claims, or retention.

- **Quotes:**
  - *"Recommendations sometimes are sponsored. Like the top few choices Amazon shopping will give you when you search for a product."* (Participant 9)
  - *"If something is clearly sponsored, I treat it like an ad."* (Participant 1)
  - *"I don't really trust recommendations, so I don't rely on them."* (Participant 2)

T4-C2 Reviews and information richness are non-negotiable trust anchors

- **Definition:** Users rely on reviews/ratings and concrete details (photos, menus) to judge quality and reduce risk.
- **Rationale:** Missing reviews pushes users off-platform and increases churn.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"If the pictures don't reflect the actual food at the restaurant, I'll be less interested in the restaurant."* (Participant 4)
  - *"The second issue is the lack of reviews. For some restaurants, there just isn't enough information to know whether they're worth trying."* (Participant 3)
  - *"I don't trust them when they feel sponsored, overly generic, or disconnected from my past behavior. If the photos don't look realistic or ratings feel inflated, I'll ignore them."* (Participant 11)

T4-C3 Coupons value clarity and redemption credibility

- **Definition:** Users need transparent deal math and redeemability; hidden terms, pricing confusion, or paywalls reduce trust and claim-to-redeem.
- **Rationale:** Conversion depends on fast comprehension of "how good is this deal" and "can I redeem it."
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Also, the happy hour pricing was confusing. Sometimes it shows dollars off, sometimes it shows the final price. If you're showing the final price, I'd love a comparison so I can tell how good the deal actually is."* (Participant 1)
  - *"The coupon is fake like you have to pay more money than it said."* (Participant 7)
  - *"I need to subscribe to some membership in order to get the coupon."* (Participant 9)

Theme 5 (T5): GenTags influence behavior as "filter + confirmation," but trust determines whether they help

- **Theme definition:** Tags mainly help users narrow choices and validate what they already want, but they only work when users trust the tags and the tag set feels manageable rather than overwhelming.

- **Business rationale:** GenTags can support conversion and repeat use only if they feel credible and non-salesy. Otherwise, they get ignored or trigger skepticism.

Codes under T5

T5-C1 Tags act as a lightweight filter and confirmation layer, not a persuasive one

- **Definition:** Tags mainly help users narrow options and confirm existing preferences; they rarely persuade on their own.
- **Rationale:** This is the realistic role GenTag can play in the journey, supporting confidence and reducing effort for users.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"I kinda have an answer before I go into this application. The tag is just confirming my choice."* (Participant 10)
  - *"Tags are mostly supporting information for me. They help filter and confirm choices, but they don't replace reviews."* (Participant 3)
  - *"If I already have a choice, they might confirm what i want or make me dismiss the idea."* (Participant 7)

T5-C2 Credibility boundary: Tags must feel review-grounded, not ad-like

- **Definition:** Tags are trusted when they align with evidence (reviews/experience); promotional or inconsistent tags get ignored and can reduce trust.
- **Rationale:** When tags appear promotional or exaggerated, users discount them; when they align with review language, they increase confidence and reduce the need to scan multiple reviews.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"And if the app doesn't have reviews, then tags become even more important, because they carry the platform's credibility."* (Participant 2)
  - *"I prefer tags extracted from the reviews. If the tags include 'bad service' or 'high tips', I will just stop wasting time and looking for another place."* (Participant 9)
  - *"If it has too many tags or the tags show different with the reviews (then tags might make choosing harder or more confusing)."* (Participant 7)

Theme 6 (T6): GenTag helps only when it is concrete, curated, and timed to the decision

- **Theme definition:** Tags are useful when they match how people decide (food-first + constraints), prioritize practical and functional ones, and are specific enough to reduce uncertainty without overload.

- **Business rationale:** GenTag is a differentiation lever, but can backfire if vague, irrelevant, or excessive.

Codes under T6

T6-C1 Natural language is food-first, then constraints/vibe

- **Definition:** Users describe intent primarily via cuisine/dish/category first, then refine with constraints and situational context.
- **Rationale:** This is the dominant retrieval mental model for restaurants and cafes; GenTags should support, not compete with, category intent.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Search for the type of cuisine that I want."* (Participant 7)
  - *"I will just search related food category or location."* (Participant 9)
  - *"Food type probably matters most."* (Participant 5)

T6-C2 Practical and functional tags are the highest-utility "decision shortcuts"

- **Definition:** Concrete constraints (price, wifi/outlets, seating, distance) help users eliminate options quickly and decide with confidence.
- **Rationale:** Practical tags reduce uncertainty and increase decision confidence, which supports faster click, claim, and redeem progression.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Practical features, because they directly affect whether I'll go."* (Participant 2)
  - *"Practical features are more helpful because they help me avoid places that won't work for what I need."* (Participant 12)
  - *"I care more about practical features, such as price range, wifi, and whether chargers are available."* (Participant 4)

T6-C3 Subjective, vague or irrelevant tags create confusion and distrust

- **Definition:** Vibe labels help only when specific and relevant; vague/subjective or mismatched tags confuse users and can erode trust.
- **Rationale:** Vibe tags can reduce uncertainty for experience-driven decisions, but vague labels can confuse and erode trust.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Yes, if there are too many tags or if they're vague or subjective. Like "Meat Lover," or "Budget Saver" is too subjective. It's a description of one group of people, which I don't trust."* (Participant 12)

- *"Tags like "good for studying" could be helpful, but vague words like "good" or "cozy" alone do not clearly describe a place. I prefer tags with specific meaning."* (Participant 8)
- *"If the tag is not related to the restaurant. For example, I want to have a French dinner and a fine dinning experience, but the tags says it's 'good for study."* (Participant 9)

<u>T6-C4 Tag overload and taxonomy quality are important to consider</u>

- **Definition:** Too many or overlapping tags overwhelm users; curation and a clean taxonomy improve scanability and usefulness.
- **Rationale:** Curation improves scanability and supports tags as a decision tool.
- **Quotes:**
  - *"Too many tags are overwhelming. I'd rather see only the top 3–5 tags that are personalized to me."* (Participant 2)
  - *"If it has too many tags I will consider it as overwhelming."* (Participant 7)
  - *"Feel like the Tag should be mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive (MECE), which means there should not be overlapped tags."* (Participant 4)

9.3 Frequency Analysis

Theme	Code	Definition	Frequency
T1 Positioning ambiguity is an acquisition problem	**T1-C1** Similar apps mismatch reveals unclear category	Users reference very different existing apps (map, review, delivery, social discovery, deal app), indicating unclear product category and value proposition.	12
	T1-C2 Users expect Voraa to add incremental value to existing habits	Users won't replace existing apps; they want Voraa to make decisions faster or cheaper.	6
T2 Inventory and local relevance are pass/fail gates for retention	**T2-C1** Limited merchant inventory triggers immediate drop-off	Users leave early when they cannot find enough appealing, relevant venues; inventory density is a prerequisite for value.	8
	T2-C2 "Nearby + familiar" is the dominant mental filter	Users evaluate usefulness through proximity, convenience, and whether venues match their real routines and familiar places.	10
	T2-C3 Location visibility and map affordance gaps	Users cannot reliably judge where venues are or how far they are due to missing or broken map/location affordances.	3
T3 Activation breaks before the first value moment	**T3-C1** Registration flow and onboarding friction causes drop-off	Sign-up and onboarding steps feel long, unskippable, or error-prone, preventing users from reaching a first value moment.	5
	T3-C2 Confusing information architecture and micro-frictions	Clutter, unclear structure, small interaction bugs, and interruptions break task flow and reduce confidence.	10

Theme	Code	Definition	Frequency
T4 Trust and price credibility are conversion gates	**T4-C1** Sponsored or "Recommended for you" content is treated as advertising	Users discount recommendations when they suspect paid placement or generic promotion, reducing exploration and conversion.	6
	T4-C2 Reviews and information richness are non-negotiable trust anchors	Users rely on reviews/ratings and concrete details (photos, menus) to judge quality and reduce risk.	12
	T4-C3 Coupon value clarity and redemption credibility	Users need transparent deal math and redeemability; hidden terms, pricing confusion, or paywalls reduce trust and claim-to-redeem.	5
T5 GenTags influence behavior as "filter + confirmation," but trust determines whether they help	**T5-C1** Tags act as a lightweight filter and confirmation layer, not a persuasive one	Tags mainly help users narrow options and confirm existing preferences; they rarely persuade on their own.	8
	T5-C2 Credibility boundary: Tags must feel review-grounded, not ad-like	Tags are trusted when they align with evidence (reviews/experience); promotional or inconsistent tags get ignored and can reduce trust.	4
T6 GenTag helps only when it is concrete, curated, and timed to the decision	**T6-C1** Natural language is food-first, then constraints/vibe	Users describe intent primarily via cuisine/dish/category first, then refine with constraints and situational context.	11
	T6-C2 Practical and functional tags are the highest-utility decision shortcuts	Concrete constraints (price, Wi-Fi/outlets, seating, distance) help users eliminate options quickly and decide with confidence.	10

Theme	Code	Definition	Frequency
	T6-C3 Subjective, vague, or irrelevant tags create confusion and distrust	Vibe labels help only when specific and relevant; vague/subjective or mismatched tags confuse users and can erode trust.	7
	T6-C4 Tag overload and taxonomy quality are important to consider	Too many or overlapping tags overwhelm users; curation and a clean taxonomy improve scanability and usefulness.	8

9.4 Data Partitioning Analysis (User Segmentation)

	Male **(P2, P6, P8, P9, P11, P12)**	**Female** **(P1, P3, P4, P5, P7, P10)**
T4 Trust and price credibility are conversion gates	Male users show trust concerns centered on system credibility and algorithmic transparency, emphasizing how the **recommendation mechanism** works and why certain options are suggested.	Female users actively look for reviews and feel uneasy when social proof is missing, highlighting the importance they place on **recommendation volume and visibility.**
	Business Implication: Male users need "how recommendations work" transparency. Add explainability and algorithm controls. Emphasize unbiased ranking vs. paid placement.	Business Implication: Reviews are non-negotiable for female conversion. Implement Google/Yelp review aggregation immediately via API to show review count and average rating prominently.
T5 GenTags influence behavior as "filter + confirmation," but trust determines whether they help	Male users are **efficiency focused,** using tags primarily as exclusion filters. They prefer tags that can be verified.	Female users demonstrate more **exploratory behavior** and show greater openness to discovering new venues.
	Business Implication: Male users want fast validation of known places. Provide one-tap exclusion filters such as *no outlets, too noisy,* or *no seating,* and bind practical tags directly to filtering controls. Messaging for this segment should emphasize speed and time saving rather than exploration.	Business Implication: Build a *Try Something New* feature supported by risk reducers such as photos, tags, and reviews to lower uncertainty. Add light gamification with rewards for exploring new venues, and leverage female early adopters as growth catalysts since they are more likely to share discoveries.
T6 GenTag helps only when it is concrete, curated, and timed to the decision	Male users tend to prioritize **functional and practical tags**, and often show skepticism toward tags that feel too subjective or opinion-driven.	Female users show higher acceptance of tags that reflect **situational and social contexts.**
	Business Implication: Male users respond best to concrete, measurable tags such as *free parking, Wi-Fi,* or *outdoor seating.* Deprioritize ambiance-heavy tags and surface practical	Business Implication: Include a balanced level of contextual tags for female users, such as *date-friendly* or *Instagrammable,* and enable filtering by

	tags first for male. Add preference learning so repeated clicks on practical tags increase ranks in future recommendations.	occasion or purpose to support intent-based discovery.

	Student (P1, P3, P4, P5, P7, P8, P9, P10, P12)	**Working Professional (P2, P6, P11)**
T1 Positioning ambiguity is an acquisition problem	Students are highly **price-motivated** and frame value through savings.	Working professionals frame value as **time savings and convenience,** not just price.
	Business Implication: Students are the core segment, since the app's differentiation centers on coupons. Partner with campus dining or nearby merchants to offer exclusive student discounts. Acquisition messaging should lead with clear savings, such as *Save $X per month on food,* supported by authentic student testimonials.	Business Implication: Professionals require a different value proposition than students. Position messaging around time saving, such as *Find lunch in 30 seconds.* Consider a premium tier with benefits like an ad-free experience, faster support, and early access to new restaurant partners.
T2 Inventory and local relevance are pass/fail gates for retention	Students are heavily constrained by **walkability and limited access to cars.** They care most about whether deals are available in the areas they already frequent, especially around campus.	Professionals show higher tolerance for longer distances compared to student, and prioritize **parking availability and car-friendly locations.**
	Business Implication: Students typically operate within a 0.5 to 1 mile decision radius due to walking constraints. Merchant acquisition should prioritize campus-adjacent locations to ensure local density. The map view becomes a critical feature for this segment, with default sorting set to nearest first.	Business Implication: Professionals typically have a 5-to-10-mile decision radius due to driving. Add an *Easy Parking* tag that can be filtered and clearly highlighted in venue details. Prioritize partnerships with restaurants that offer validated or convenient parking.

T4 Trust and price credibility are conversion gates	Students tend to form trust through a combination of signals such as friends, social media, and reviews, and are **highly influenced by peer feedback and online content.**	Professionals are generally **skeptical of recommendation systems** and rely on multiple trust signals before engaging. They are especially sensitive to coupon terms, subscription requirements, and whether deals are genuinely usable.
	Business Implication: Students often trust Instagram and TikTok more than in-app reviews. Add social features and encourage user-generated content. Partner with student influencers for authentic discovery, and make sharing frictionless with simple branded templates that highlight the venue and deal.	Business Implication: Build radical transparency by explaining why venues are recommended, allowing users to adjust preference settings, and clearly labeling any sponsored placements. Strengthen credibility by surfacing trusted editorial sources alongside user reviews.

9.5 Negative Case Analysis

Case 1

"When apps show 'Recommended for you', do you usually click on them? Why or why not?"

"Not really, Because from my experience with similar apps, they most likely don't match my taste."

(Participant 6)

This contradicts the assumption that poor recommendations are a Voraa-specific problem. P6's distrust is based on accumulated negative experiences across multiple apps, not Voraa alone. This suggests that recommendation skepticism is a learned behavior from the broader app ecosystem. Voraa must actively **differentiate its recommendation logic** and communicate **WHY** its recommendations are different to overcome pre-existing bias.

Case 2

"If I already have a choice, they might confirm what I want or make me dismiss the idea."

(Participant 7)

This contradicts the assumption that tags only provide positive confirmation. P7 uses tags to reject options, not just validate them. This suggests negative tags ("bad service," "high tips" per P9) may be **more valuable** than positive ones for decision-making. It indicates Voraa should **surface critical and negative signals** prominently as transparency builds trust.

Case 3

"The onboarding challenge felt unrealistic. Tapping 180 times in 20 seconds to win a reward felt impossible and made the app seem untrustworthy."

(Participant 11)

This contradicts the focus on form-field friction in T3-C1. P11's drop-off during onboarding isn't about required fields, it's about a gamified task that felt manipulative. This suggests that activation problems include **unrealistic promises.** It indicates that "growth hacks" can actually **harm trust** if they feel dishonest, especially for professional and skeptical users.

Case 4

"One important thing is: when the app links out to Google Maps, I would rather read reviews there because Google Maps already has much richer information."

(Participant 2)

This contradicts the main finding that missing in-app reviews is always a dealbreaker. It indicates that some users are fine with an **"external proof"** workflow, using Voraa mainly as a **coupon layer** on top of existing review habits.

Case 5

"When I check the map function, and there's no pings on that map, and that was really confusing then, because in the beginning, I thought that oh, no restaurants showed up because it was in the midnight."

(Participant 5)

This contradicts the idea that map view is inherently intuitive (T2-C3 frames it as just an "affordance gap"). P5's confusion suggests a deeper mental model mismatch: empty maps signal "closed/unavailable" not "low inventory." It indicates that when map view is empty, Voraa should show explicit messaging like ***"We're growing our Seattle restaurant network—check back soon"*** rather than letting users invent incorrect explanations.

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